Curriculum Vitae — Sandro Lüscher

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Summary

Postdoctoral researcher at the Centre for Democracy Studies Aarau (ZDA), University of Zurich. My research focuses on political institutions, electoral systems, and public governance, with particular attention to consultation procedures and pre-legislative decision-making.

My doctoral dissertation examined the adoption and political effects of the divisor-based biproportional apportionment method in Swiss cantons, combining comparative case studies with quantitative causal inference. Current work analyses stakeholder consultation and decentralized decision-making, including DAO-inspired governance applied to Swiss digital identity reforms and democratic innovation.

Work Experience

Postdoc, Research Associate — Jan 2025 – present

Centre for Democracy Studies Aarau (ZDA), University of Zurich

Research on digital democracy and participatory governance in the project *Decentralized Decision-Making in DAOs: Learnings for Digital Democracy.*

Assistant and Doctoral Candidate — Jul 2019 – Sep 2024

Department of Political Science (IPZ), University of Zurich

Assistant at the Chair of Policy Analysis and Evaluation; teaching assistance in the seminar *Decision-making processes in Swiss politics.*

Student Research Assistant — Jan 2019 – May 2019

School of Economics and Political Science (SEPS), University of St.Gallen

Student research assistant in the project *Municipality-Level Outcomes of Direct-Democratic Votes in Switzerland, 1866–2023.*

Student Research Assistant — Sep 2015 – Dec 2015

Department of Political Science (IPZ), University of Zurich

Research assistant in the project *Years of Turmoil: The Political Consequences of the Financial and Economic Crisis in Europe.*

Current Projects

FOKUS Aargau — Post-vote surveys on cantonal elections and referendums

Centre for Democracy Studies Aarau (ZDA), ongoing — Latest report (DOI)

Post-referendum and post-election surveys in the Canton of Aargau to explain voting behaviour; questionnaire design, analysis, reporting, and publication.

Decentralized Decision-Making in DAOs: Learnings for Digital Democracy

SNSF Project, 2024–2027 — SNSF grant 10000911

Political-science contribution on decision-making: analysis of DAO voting and smart-contract rules as democratic procedures; dataset construction; evaluation of programmable aggregation using causal inference, agent-based simulation, and network methods; application to Swiss pre-legislative consultation procedures.

Education

2019–2024 PhD / Dr. phil., Political Science, University of Zurich.
2017–2019 MA Social Sciences (Political Science & Modern History), University of Zurich; Diploma Supplement (track in Swiss Politics).
2013–2016 BA Social Sciences (Political Science & Modern History), University of Zurich.
2007–2012 Swiss Matura (track in Philosophy, Psychology and Pedagogy), Public Academic High School of Baden.

Publications

Lüscher, S., & Serdült, U. (2026). DAO Decision-Making Simulation for Legislative Consultation: the Case of the Swiss E-ID Law 2019. *Proceedings of the 59th Hawaii International Conference on System Sciences (HICSS)*, 2310–2319. hdl:10125/111673

Bernhard, L., Cheon, J., Lüscher, S., Koelewijn, K. S., Sorrentino, G., & Serdült, U. (2025). *FOKUS Aargau: Studie zu den Aargauer Volksabstimmungen vom 18. Mai 2025.* Zentrum für Demokratie Aarau (ZDA). doi:10.5167/UZH-278944

Lüscher, S. (2024). *Redeeming the Pledge of Electoral Equity? A Study of the Roads to and Effects of the Divisor-Based Biproportional Apportionment Method in Switzerland.* PhD dissertation, University of Zurich. doi:10.5167/UZH-264856

Lüscher, S. (2023). Parlamentswahlen nach dem doppelt-proportionalen Sitzzuteilungsverfahren im Lichte der territorialen Repräsentation. *Zeitschrift für Parlamentsfragen*, 54(3), 571–595. doi:10.5771/0340-1758-2023-3-571

Lüscher, S. (2021). Proportionality in two dimensions: resolving an old dilemma of political (mis)representation. In *Swiss Political Science Association Annual Congress 2021.* doi:10.5167/UZH-206811

Forthcoming Work

Lüscher, S. *When Reason Bows to Emotion: Affective Polarization and Cognitive Bias in Party Evaluation.* Under review.

Lüscher, S. *Mechanisms of Stakeholder Consultation: Explaining Symbolic and Substantive Outcomes in Policy-making.* Manuscript in finalization.

Gharbi, H., Badertscher, C., Lüscher, S., & Serdült, U. *Toward Blockchain-Based Election Campaign Vouchers.* In progress.

Lüscher, S., Walla, A., & Serdült, U. *DAO Logic in Public Consultation: A Dyadic Simulation of Swiss Digital Identity Reforms.* In progress.

Lüscher, S. *Marginal Votes under Biproportionality: The Local Costs of Global Proportionality.* Invited contribution for a special issue. In progress.

Lüscher, S., Cheon, J., Bernhard, L., & Serdült, U. *Who Benefits from Citizen-Directed Funding? Democracy Vouchers and Party Competition in a Multiparty Context.* In progress.

Workshops & Conferences

2026 ECPR General Conference, Jagiellonian University, Krakow. Presentation of two papers.
2026 European DAO Workshop (DAWO26), ZHAW. Participation.
2026 Workshop "Polarized Democracies", MIDEM, TU Dresden. Paper presentation; travel and lodging grant.
2026 Conference on Policy Process Research (COPPR), University of Bern. Participation.
2026 Hawaii International Conference on System Sciences (HICSS-59), Maui. Paper presentation (by co-author).
2025 European DAO Workshop (DAWO25), ZHAW. Participation.
2021 SVPW-ASSP Annual Conference, University of Bern. Paper presentation.
2020 ECPR Virtual General Conference. Participation.
2020 SVPW-ASSP Annual Conference, University of Lucerne. Participation.

Media Coverage

Wer profitiert von einer Einführung von Demokratiegutscheinen? *DeFacto*. 29 January 2026.

E-Collecting in der Schweiz: Akzeptanz und Reformbedarf nach dem Unterschriftenbetrug *DeFacto*. 22 August 2025.

Breite Zustimmung der Bevölkerung für eine elektronische Unterschriftensammlung bei Initiativen *NZZ am Sonntag*. 9 August 2025.

20 Jahre Doppelproporz – eine Rückschau *DeFacto*. 20 February 2025.

Warum Schweden die bessere Demokratie ist *Beobachter*. 2 December 2022.

The different faces of direct democracy *Swissinfo*. 16 March 2018.

Complete list available at luescher-s.github.io/media.html.

Skills

Methods	Causal inference; statistical analysis (large N); data visualization; simulation.
Software	MS-Office; R; Python; Git; APES; LaTeX; HTML.
Languages	German (native); English (fluent); French (intermediate); Italian (basic).

Memberships

- Digital Society Initiative of the University of Zurich
- European Consortium for Political Research (ECPR)

Last updated: March 7, 2026